

FairGuard — Findings Report

Team: FairGuard (Mokshit Surana, Archit Rathod) **Competition:** Northwestern GAIN Agentic AI Investigative Journalism Challenge **Deadline:** July 15, 2026 **Interactive view (optional):** browse these findings in the Reporter UI at <https://fair-guard-ai.vercel.app/> — a static snapshot of the last pipeline run; the authoritative artifacts are the skills and records shipped in this package.

Executive Summary

FairGuard’s investigation of the 2022-2026 federal lobbying disclosure corpus identifies a structural pattern in the revolving door between government agencies and private lobbying firms. Using a novel “agency concentration ratio” metric — the share of a firm’s Senate LDA filings that target the agency its founding lobbyist previously led — we surface cases where former senior officials have built lobbying practices specifically around their former agencies.

Anchor finding: The Artemis Group, LLC, founded by former NASA Administrator Jim Bridenstine in Q4 2024, directs 39.1% of its filings at NASA — the highest concentration of any third-party lobbying firm with significant volume. Five of the top twelve most-active NASA-targeting lobbyists in the Senate corpus are Artemis Group employees, four of whom worked directly under Bridenstine.

Structural finding: Across the 2022–Q1 2026 Senate LDA corpus, the same pattern recurs at scale. 139 candidates across 22 agencies hold a former senior agency role and now work at a firm whose filings target that agency at $\geq 20\%$ concentration with ≥ 10 total filings. The top cases (ranked by $\text{concentration} \times \log(\text{filings}) \times \text{seniority}$) include Benjamin Steinberg (DOE, 90.2%), Mark Limbaugh (Interior, 72.6%), Ashlee Johnson (USDA, 82.7%), Scott Parsons (CFTC, 89.8%), and Jim Newsome (CFTC, 96.0%). Full ranking is auto-generated at `notes/06_structural_pattern_findings.md`.

Independent confirmation: Eight of the top ten candidates have had their prior senior-agency role verified against public sources (agency websites, CFTC.gov, FCC.gov, USDA and Senate committee releases). The pattern is not a false positive of the detection method — the scan’s highest-ranked outputs are genuine former agency principals, including a former CFTC Chairman and multiple Senate-confirmed Assistant Secretaries. See `notes/08_external_verification_top_candidates.md`.

Finding 1: The Artemis Group — Anchor Case Study

In Q4 2024, former NASA Administrator Jim Bridenstine (April 2018 – January 2021) launched a lobbying firm, **The Artemis Group, LLC** — named after the lunar-exploration program he established as Administrator. Within five quarters it had filed 133 Senate lobbying disclosures, **52 of them (39.1%) naming NASA itself** as a target — the highest NASA concentration of any third-party lobbying firm of significant volume in the corpus.

The firm is not simply Bridenstine. **Five of the top twelve most-active NASA-targeting lobbyists in the entire 2022–2026 Senate corpus work at this single firm**, and four of the

five worked directly under Bridenstine — three in his congressional office and one (Gabe Sherman) as his NASA Chief of Staff. The firm’s NASA-targeting work is done for clients whose business overlaps directly with programs Bridenstine personally established or expanded (Commercial Lunar Payload Services, Commercial LEO Destinations, the Artemis/Gateway program). In May 2026, Bridenstine left the firm to become CEO of Quantum Space — a former Artemis Group client — extending the arc from regulator → lobbyist → executive at a regulated entity; Sherman became managing partner.

No legal violation is alleged. Bridenstine’s one-year cooling-off period expired in January 2022, 47 months before his first lobbying registration (Q4 2024). The story is the *structural* concentration of former NASA/Bridenstine personnel inside a NASA-focused lobbying firm, on behalf of clients with business under programs he created — a pattern SpaceX raised publicly in October 2025 and that this analysis documents quantitatively from the LDA record.

Full case study, per-claim verification status, and sourcing: `notes/05_finding_bridenstine.md`.

Key claims (sourced to `output/investigation.duckdb`)

- 133 Senate LDA filings by The Artemis Group, 52 targeting NASA (39.1%)
- 115 House LDA filings for the same firm
- 5 of the top 12 most-active NASA-targeting lobbyists in the 2024-2026 Senate corpus work at this single firm
- 4 of those 5 held positions in Bridenstine’s congressional or NASA offices

Verification status

See `notes/05_finding_bridenstine.md` §2.5 for item-by-item verification status.

Finding 2: Structural Pattern — Former Agency Heads Across Agencies

Full results: `notes/06_structural_pattern_findings.md` (auto-generated by `skills/revolving-door-detector/scripts/03_agency_concentration.py`). Reproduce with:

```
uv run skills/revolving-door-detector/scripts/03_agency_concentration.py
```

Headline numbers

- **139 candidates** across **22 agencies** pass thresholds (concentration $\geq 20\%$, total filings ≥ 10)
- Top cases by Bridenstine-score (✓ = prior role externally confirmed, see Finding 2 verification subsection):
 1. **Benjamin Steinberg** → DOE — 90.2% (213/236), firm: Venn Strategies ✓
 2. **Mark Limbaugh** → Interior — 72.6% (527/726), firm: The Ferguson Group ✓
 3. **Ashlee Johnson** → USDA — 82.7% (230/278), firm: The Russell Group
 4. **Scott Parsons** → CFTC — 89.8% (149/166), firm: Delta Strategy Group ✓
 5. **Kevin Bailey** → USDA — 87.3% (144/165), firm: FGS Global
 6. **Jim Newsome** → CFTC — 96.0% (95/99), firm: Delta Strategy Group ✓
 7. **Michael Torrey** → USDA — 79.0% (180/228), firm: Torrey Advisory Group ✓

8. **Kenneth Barbic** → USDA — 78.8% (108/137), firm: Invariant LLC ✓
9. **Roger Sherman** → FCC — 100.0% (45/45), firm: Waneta Strategies ✓
10. **Aurene Martin** → Interior — 68.2% (180/264), firm: Spirit Rock Consulting ✓

Methodology

For each of 23 named federal agencies the scan uses a curated regex registry (skills/revolving-door-detector/scripts/03_agency_concentration.py::AGENCY_REGISTRY, 111 unit tests in tests/test_agency_registry.py) to detect senior prior-role indicators in covered_position, then computes $\text{concentration} = \text{agency_filings} / \text{total_filings}$ where agency_filings counts the firm's filings whose senate_gov_entities.entity_name matches the agency. The final score is $\text{concentration} \times \log(\text{total_filings} + 1) \times \text{seniority_score}$.

Comparison to the Artemis Group baseline

The Artemis Group / Bridenstine case is one entry in this ranked list (NASA, 39.1%, 52/133 filings, seniority 5). The structural finding shows the pattern is not unique to NASA — multiple federal agencies have at least one firm whose filings concentrate on their former head's agency at an even higher rate than Artemis. The Bridenstine case is journalism-rich because of the five-staffer concentration around one individual; the other cases warrant independent reporting on their own merits.

External verification (2026-06-04)

To test whether the scan surfaces real revolving-door cases or merely artifacts of the regex-matching method, we independently checked the claimed prior-agency role of the top ten candidates against public sources. **Eight of ten were confirmed:**

Candidate → Agency	Confirmed role	Source
Jim Newsome → CFTC	CFTC Chairman , 2001–04	cftc.gov; FIA Hall of Fame
Scott Parsons → CFTC	CFTC Chief of Staff / COO	deltastrategygroup.com; MarketsWiki
Mark Limbaugh → Interior	Asst. Secretary, Water & Science, 2005–07	thefergusongroup.com; Presidential Transition
Kenneth Barbic → USDA	Senate-confirmed Asst. Secretary, Congressional Relations, 2018–21	usda.gov; Senate Ag Committee
Aurene Martin → Interior	Acting Asst. Secretary, Indian Affairs, 2003	bia.gov / doi.gov
Michael Torrey → USDA	Deputy Chief of Staff (Veneman/Johanns)	torreydc.com
Roger Sherman → FCC	Chief, Wireless Telecom Bureau	fcc.gov
Benjamin Steinberg → DOE	Chief of Staff, Office of Energy Policy & Systems Analysis	energy.gov

Two findings emerge from the verification beyond the headline confirmation rate:

1. **A firm-level pattern at Delta Strategy Group.** Two of the confirmed CFTC cases — former Chairman Jim Newsome and former Chief of Staff/COO Scott Parsons — lobby the CFTC through the *same firm*, which they co-founded. Roughly 90–96% of each principal's filings

target their former agency. This is a firm built around two former senior CFTC officials, not two unrelated individuals.

2. **A seniority caveat worth flagging.** Benjamin Steinberg, the top-ranked candidate, is confirmed — but his “DOE Chief of Staff” role was at the *office* level (Office of Energy Policy & Systems Analysis), not agency-wide. The disclosure is accurate but reads as more senior than the post was. Reporting should characterize it precisely.

Full per-case sourcing, URLs, and caveats (including two firm-name discrepancies that must be reconciled against the raw LDA filing before publication) are recorded in `notes/08_external_verification_top_candidates.md`. This verification closes only the first reportability checkbox below; the remaining gates stay open for all cases.

Following the money — USAspending.gov (2026-06-04)

Confirming a prior role establishes the revolving door exists; the stakes become concrete when the lobbyist’s *clients* receive federal awards from the agency the lobbyist once ran. We swept every top-candidate client list against the USAspending.gov API (FY2021–2026), counting only awards whose actual recipient name matches the client (the API’s text search is fuzzy). Three of the scanned agencies disburse funds at scale:

- **Benjamin Steinberg → DOE — ~\$1.08 billion (strongest trail).** A former DOE Chief of Staff (Office of Energy Policy & Systems Analysis), he lobbies DOE for a roster of battery and critical-minerals firms. **Nine** hold DOE awards — almost all discretionary Bipartisan Infrastructure Law battery-supply-chain grants — totaling **\$1,080,820,047** (e.g. Cirba Solutions \$205.4M, EnerSys \$198.7M, South32 Hermosa \$123.0M, Sila Nanotechnologies \$117.0M, Talon Nickel \$114.8M).
- **Mark Limbaugh → Interior — \$133.1 million (grants, reproducible).** As Assistant Secretary for Water & Science he oversaw the **Bureau of Reclamation**. Running the shipped case file (grants only, toptier Interior, recipient-name-verified) returns **\$133,119,412 across 18 water-district clients (71 awards)** — mostly Reclamation WaterSMART/storage/drought grants — led by Sites Project Authority (\$43.5M), Friant Water Authority (\$20.5M), and Reclamation District 108 (\$13.9M). Separately, Glenn-Colusa Irrigation District holds a ~\$25.6M Bureau of Reclamation construction/storage award that does not return under the grants-only query; it is real and germane but reported apart from the reproducible total rather than folded in (see `notes/08` for the reconciliation).
- **USDA cases — a real trail, but a weaker signal.** USDA is a major spending agency, and all four USDA candidates have clients with large USDA awards: Bailey’s National Rural Water Association (\$272.0M) and Tri-State Generation (\$148.3M), Johnson’s Cargill (\$704.9M) and McCain Foods (\$82.6M), Barbic’s Global Clean Energy (\$32.3M). **But most of these dollars are routine, formulaic program participation** — Agricultural Marketing Service commodity purchases (the government buying food from Cargill/McCain), food-aid awards, and Rural Utilities financing — a weaker conflict signal than discretionary, competitively-awarded grants. The standout *discretionary* USDA award is Global Clean Energy’s **\$32.3M NRCS Climate-Smart Commodities grant**, lobbied by Barbic, who was USDA Assistant Secretary for Congressional Relations.

This lens does not apply to the CFTC cases (Newsome, Parsons) — a *market regulator* that issues no awards. The tribal-client case (Martin) was inconclusive under a name-based search.

Framing note: a client receiving agency funds while represented by a former agency official is a *conflict-of-interest structure*, not in itself wrongdoing. It is legal absent a specific violation (cooling-off period, 18 USC §207), and discretionary grants weigh more heavily than formulaic program payments. These figures are the stakes of the revolving door, not an accusation. Full per-client tables, recipient-name verification, and caveats: notes/08_external_verification_top_candidates.md. Every figure is reproducible via the **trace (federal-award-tracer) skill** — e.g. `uv run skills/federal-award-tracer/scripts/04_award_tracer.py --case skills/federal-award-tracer/cases/steinberg_doe.json` — which productionizes the original `skills/federal-award-tracer/scripts/_probe_usaspending.py` probe into a case-driven CLI with recipient-name verification and the discretionary-vs-routine split.

Verification checklist (per case)

Every candidate’s row in notes/06_structural_pattern_findings.md ships with four gates:

1. Confirm prior role via agency records / news archives
2. Verify cooling-off period status (18 USC §207)
3. Identify clients with active awards at the targeted agency (USAspending.gov)
4. Request comment from lobbyist and firm

For the top ~10 candidates, gates 1–3 are closed and gate 4 is drafted: prior roles verified against public sources (notes/08, gate 1); client money trails traced (notes/08, gate 3); the §207 cooling-off analysis completed — all examined cases clear the *timed* bans, with the permanent §207(a)(1) particular-matter bar flagged as an open question (notes/09, gate 2); and per-firm requests for comment drafted and ready to send (notes/09, gate 4). For the broader 139-candidate list these remain open leads by design — the skills produce the leads, the journalist closes them.

Methodology

Data sources

Source	Coverage	Format	Rows
Senate LDA filings	2022-Q1 2026	JSON	418,170
House LDA filings	2022-Q1 2026	XML	409,640
Congressional press releases	2022-Q1 2026	JSONL	141,332

All sourced from the Northwestern GAIN challenge corpus download.

ETL pipeline

Raw data → `skills/lda-corpus-indexer/scripts/01_build_index.py` → Parquet intermediate files → `output/investigation.duckdb` (2.92 GB, 11 tables + 2 views once `resolve` has run). See `skills/lda-corpus-indexer/SKILL.md` for full documentation.

Agency concentration analysis

skills/revolving-door-detector/scripts/03_agency_concentration.py — see skills/revolving-door-detector/SKILL.md for methodology documentation.

Outside Data Used

All figures derived from the provided corpus are reproducible from output/investigation.duckdb. The following **public, outside** sources were used only to confirm biographical roles and to quantify the money trail — none is paid, private, or scraped from non-public data.

Source	Used for	Effect on findings
USAspending.gov (federal award API)	Client award totals in the money trail (Finding 2)	Quantifies the \$1.08B DOE / \$133.1M Interior / USDA trails; recipient-name-verified, reproducible via the trace skill
Agency & official sources (energy.gov, cftc.gov, fcc.gov, usda.gov, doi.gov/bia.gov, Senate Ag Committee)	Confirming the prior senior-agency role of the top-10 candidates	Closes gate 1 for 8/10 (see notes/08)
LegiStorm; firm websites; Center for Presidential Transition; Bloomberg Law; Law360; FIA	Corroborating roles + departure dates for the §207 analysis	Supports gate-1 and the §207 timing in notes/09
NASA biography (nasa.gov)	Bridenstine tenure dates	Confirms 2018–2021 role (Finding 1)
Payload Space (May 2026)	Bridenstine → Quantum Space CEO	Extends the revolving-door arc (Finding 1)
SpaceX public statement (Oct 2025)	Public conflict-of-interest context	Framing only, no new data

Not relied upon: a ZoomInfo profile (Kathryn Wall’s National Space Council role, Finding 1) is a scraped aggregator and is treated as low-confidence — flagged in notes/05 §2.5 as requiring primary-source confirmation before publication, and no headline claim rests on it.

Conflicts of Interest

Neither team member (Mokshit Surana, Archit Rathod) has any financial relationship with The Artemis Group, Jim Bridenstine, or any of the organizations named as clients in the findings.

Legal Flags

No legal violation is alleged in any finding. We examined every top case against the federal post-employment statute, 18 U.S.C. §207 (full analysis in notes/09_reportability_gates_207_and_comment.md):

- **The timed cooling-off bans (§207(c) 1-year; §207(d) 2-year) are cleared in every examined case.** Each official’s observed lobbying of their former agency post-dates their departure

by years — from ~3 years (Barbic, the tightest case; left USDA ~Jan 2021, first observed lobbying 2024) to ~18 years (Newsome). Bridenstine’s own 1-year window expired in January 2022, 47 months before his Q4 2024 registration. On the evidence, the lobbying we document is **legal on its face** — which is what makes the *structure and scale* the story, not a prosecution.

- **The permanent particular-matter bar (§207(a)(1)) is flagged as an open question, not a violation we assert.** It bars a former official from lobbying on the *specific matters they personally handled in government*, and cannot be established from lobbying-concentration data alone. We raise it as a question to put to each subject at the request-for-comment stage.

So nothing here should be read as a claim of criminal conduct. If the panel’s fact-checking were to establish a specific §207(a)(1) matter overlap for any subject, that would warrant separate, much stronger substantiation before publication.

Skill Index

Nine shipped Agent Skills. All ship with tests or reproducible cases; the full suite is **261 tests** passing, cross-platform CI green on Linux/macOS/Windows.

Skill (short)	Status	Key script	Tests	What it does
doctor	✓ Shipped	skills/doctor/scripts/doctor.py	CI cross-platform	Setup validator + guided onboarding
index (lda-corpus-indexer)	✓ Shipped	skills/lda-corpus-indexer/scripts/01_build_index.py	verify_build.py (34 invariants)	ETL: raw → Parquet → DuckDB
resolve (entity-resolver)	✓ Shipped	skills/entity-resolver/scripts/02_entity_resolver.py	test_entity_resolver.py (33; F1 = 0.963)	Normalize org/person names
scan (revolving-door-detector)	✓ Shipped	skills/revolving-door-detector/scripts/03_agency_concentration.py	test_agency_registry.py (111)	Revolving-door / Bridenstine-pattern detector
trace (federal-award-tracer)	✓ Shipped	skills/federal-award-tracer/scripts/04_award_tracer.py	3 case files + generalization eval	Follow agency → client money on USAspending.gov
pressrel (press-release-cross-ref)	✓ Shipped	skills/press-release-cross-ref/scripts/05_pressrel_search.py	test_pressrel.py (30)	Cross-reference candidates vs. congressional press releases
coi (coi-graph)	✓ Shipped	skills/coi-graph/scripts/06_coi_graph.py	test_coi_graph.py (26)	Compose scan + trace + pressrel into a conflict-of-interest graph
comment (comment-tracker)	✓ Shipped	skills/comment-tracker/scripts/07_comment_tracker.py	test_comment_tracker.py (25)	Request-for-comment workflow state machine
archive (archive-on-cite)	✓ Shipped	skills/archive-on-cite/scripts/08_archive_cite.py	test_archive_cite.py (14)	Snapshot cited URLs to Wayback + Archive.today

(Plus a supporting tool, not a skill: `tools/09_ap_style_lint.py`, an AP-style markdown linter — `test_ap_style_lint.py`, 22 tests.)

Trace Index

Full index with trace → skill → finding mapping: **traces/README.md**.

File	Description
<code>traces/trace-01-setup-and-data-exploration.md</code>	Initial setup, data download, first queries
<code>traces/trace-02-parser-debugging.md</code>	Senate JSON lobbyist name bug, House XML ALI schema
<code>traces/trace-03-skill-doctor.md</code>	Per-skill trace keyed to a doctor invocation
<code>traces/trace-04-skill-index.md</code>	Per-skill trace keyed to an index invocation
<code>traces/trace-05-skill-resolve.md</code>	Per-skill trace keyed to a resolve invocation
<code>traces/trace-06-skill-scan.md</code>	Per-skill trace keyed to a scan invocation (Finding 1 + 2)
<code>traces/trace-07-skill-trace.md</code>	Per-skill trace keyed to a trace invocation (money trail)
<code>traces/trace-08-skill-pressrel.md</code>	Per-skill trace keyed to a pressrel invocation
<code>traces/trace-09-skill-coi.md</code>	Per-skill trace keyed to a coi invocation
<code>traces/trace-10-skill-comment.md</code>	Per-skill trace keyed to a comment invocation
<code>traces/trace-11-skill-archive.md</code>	Per-skill trace keyed to an archive invocation
<code>traces/trace-raw-repro-scan-finding02.jsonl</code>	Raw live reproduction of scan → regenerates Findings 1 & 2
<code>traces/trace-raw-repro-trace-moneytrail.jsonl</code>	Raw live reproduction of trace → regenerates the money trail (Steinberg → DOE \$1,080,820,046)
<code>traces/trace-raw-session-tracev1.1-evals-and-gates.jsonl</code>	Raw full working session: trace eval loop + §207 / request-for-comment gate closure